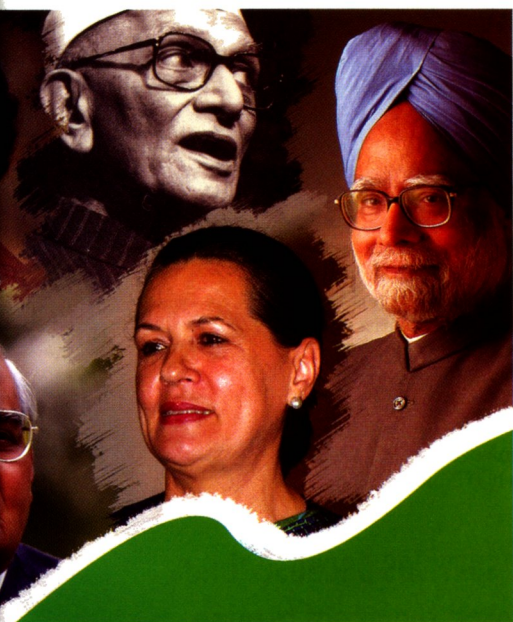




ingly incompatible together. The Indian ruling elite is a united front.

The new political order is born out of the debris of Congressism as a political culture. There was a continuity when power passed from Nehru to Indira Gandhi to Rajiv Gandhi. Post-Rajiv, the Congress began to lose its social base that could for so long accommodate almost all caste and communal aspirations. Nehru had the post-Independence aura of the liberator. Indira outsmarted the Syndicate and split the party to emerge as the awesome Mother India. With the liberation of Bangladesh, the Mrs G mythology was complete. Rajiv Gandhi, who owed his massive victory to the funeral pyre of his mother, failed to renew the mandate because he refused to share power with regional satraps.

Rajiv's widow, however, is managing better. Remember her driving down to the Shahjahan Road flat of Mayawati to seek the Dalit diva's blessing for the Congress candidate for the presidency? Or, for that matter, the Congress chief minister of Maharashtra desperately seeking the

**India remains united politically
as well as geographically
because our power elite had mastered the art
of mergers and acquisitions
much before India Inc did.**



darshan of the Shiv Sena marshal Bal Thackeray at Matoshree? Or the ideological compulsion of Sharad Pawar in 2004 when he dropped in at 10 Janpath to declare support to the same Sonia Gandhi against whom he had once raised the bogey of foreign nationality and walked out of the Congress? Or take a look at the Union Cabinet. Lalu Prasad Yadav, Ram Vilas Paswan, Shankarsinh Vaghela, Jaipal Reddy, all once victims of Congress's war against democracy, are eager Sonia-ites today. What happens at the Centre is replicated in the states too. Both BJP and Samajwadi Party were once Mayawati's friends. It may sound sacrilegious to some today but once upon a time in Bihar, a coalition government led by Congress leader Mahamaya Prasad Sinha had ministers from the Communist Party of India and the Jan Sangh.

I still remember Devi Lal, who along with Chandra Shekhar toppled the V.P. Singh govern-



SAURABH SINGH

You don't have to look beyond UPA for its immediate manifestation. UPA is a Unique Power Agreement between various caste and regional groups, where both ideology and idealism have ceased to be the agents of unity. Commitment to a Common Minimum Programme is nothing more than a post-election gimmick. What is written in it is not meant to be a covenant between the elected and the electorate. Neither is it a pledge to unity. It is not conviction but convenience dictated by the exigencies of power that keeps the political class together. If there is no permanency about the Indian coalition, which in itself is a conglomeration of disparate ideas of India, it is because for most political parties, the only ideology that matters is power. They change partners the way they forget promises—at the drop of a slogan.

Their floating flirtations with power have, in a way, sustained the solidity of our democracy, no matter how volatile it is. The dynamics of power sharing has not weakened our parliamentary system but stretched its possibilities. Imagine the enormity of the Indian diversity: a population of more than a billion; 4,000 languages and dialects; 30 states; nearly a dozen national parties and several score regional parties. Certainly not a recipe for political unity. Nations with less linguistic or cultural diversity have fallen apart. India survives because it has mastered the art of turning many into one. Power brings the seem-